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WITH CATCHY CAMPAIGNS LIKE PAYCM AND '40% COMMISSION SARKAR', ALONG WITH QUIRKY BUT EFFECTIVE MESSAGING, THE CONGRESS MOUNTED A NARRATIVE FOCUSED ON LOCAL ISSUES

to retain Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh and win back Madhya Pradesh, where it is the chief opponent of the BJP (*see accompanying story*). While the Congress may not be able to replicate the Karnataka model in these states, it holds many lessons for the party in the battles ahead. Here is the inside story of how the Congress pulled off a spectacular victory and what it means for the future.

LESSON 1: THE EARLY BIRD GETS THE VOTE

Unlike in the past, the Congress kicked off its campaign to win Karnataka almost two and a half years before the polls. In March 2020, six months before Surjewala was made state in-charge, the party high command appointed Shivakumar as the new KPCC president. A seven-time MLA, Shivakumar had a reputation of getting things done. Behind his image of being a hustler lay extreme tenacity and undiluted loyalty to the party, particularly to the Gandhi family. As though to herald a new start, one of the first things Shivakumar did was to renovate the dilapidated KPCC headquarters on Queens Road, giving it a facelift by adorning it with Greco-Roman pillars, an architectural style he seems particularly fond of, and speeding up the construction of a new state-of-the-art complex behind it.

Next, he revamped the party structure, choosing to adopt what a colleague calls "the Kamaraj Plan", as part of which every key leader was asked to head one key party organisation (see *The Congress A-Team*). Among them was Priyank Kharge, a former cabinet minister who looks a younger version of his father Mallikarjun Kharge, Congress national president. Priyank, who was made head of communications, speaks appreciatively of Shivakumar, saying, "Everyone had their task cut out and was monitored closely. His ability to work for the party relentlessly and make political manoeuvres requiring accurate intelligence was inspiring. He is better-wired than most of us."

With Surjewala coming on board, the KPCC gained a decisive edge. The affable Surjewala is a consensus-builder and a workaholic with a habit of holding meetings even at 3 am. He warned his team, "*Na sounga, na sone doonga* (won't sleep, won't let you sleep)." As the Covid crisis engulfed the state, the party proceeded to make its presence felt. Party MLAs and cadres were told to go out and help people, including purchasing food, vegetables and medicines and distributing them among the needy. As one of them reveals, "We were told to use all the 'resources' we had for social service." The party also highlighted the failures of the BJP government headed by B.S. Yediyurappa, the ageing Lingayat stalwart, in tackling the pandemic. The allegations that the chief minister had left much of the governance to his younger son, Vijayendra, who ran the show behind the scenes, helped.

Under pressure from the high command, Yediyurappa stepped down as chief minister in July 2021, while the pan-